Many Ways to Do One Thing

Civic Skill: Difference | EYLF: EYLF Outcome 2 (Community) & Outcome 4 (Learning) | Duration: 20–30 minutes | Age: 4–6 years

LEARNING INTENTION

Children will discover that the same task can be done in multiple valid ways, building an early understanding that difference does not imply wrong or better — just different.

SUCCESS CRITERIA

- I can show or describe a way of doing something that is different from my friend's way.
- I can say 'different, not wrong' when I see someone do something a different way.
- I can be curious about a different way instead of saying mine is best.

MATERIALS

- A simple task that has multiple valid approaches: tying/fastening something, building a bridge from blocks, drawing the same animal, folding paper
- A display board labelled 'Many Ways'
- Camera or tablet to photograph different approaches
- Picture book: 'What Do You Do With a Problem?' by Kobi Yamada

ACTIVITY STEPS

1. BOOK OPENER (5 min): Read 'What Do You Do With a Problem?' Focus on: the same problem can be approached completely differently. The story has a resolution, but the approach is the point.

2. TASK INTRODUCTION (3 min): Present the task. 'I want everyone to do this task — but here's the rule: you cannot copy exactly what someone else is doing. Your way and their way can both work perfectly.'

3. TASK TIME (8 min): Children work individually or in pairs. Educator actively narrates differences: 'Look — Amir did it this way. Priya did it that way. Both work!' Resist any tendency to demonstrate a 'right' way first.

4. GALLERY WALK (5 min): Photograph or display each approach. Walk around together. 'What's different about each one? Did all of them work?' Emphasise: 'How many ways did we find to do one thing?'

5. VOCABULARY BUILDER (2 min): Introduce the phrase 'different, not wrong.' Practice saying it together. Ask: 'When else could we use this phrase today?'

EXTENSIONS

- Apply 'many ways' to morning routines — who does their shoes differently, who packs their bag differently
- Mathematics extension: show 5 = 3+2 = 4+1 = 2+2+1 — 'Many ways to make the same number'
- Culture connection: introduce the same food made differently across cultures — e.g., flatbreads from different countries

ASSESSMENT

- Observation: Does the child accept another's approach without claiming it is wrong?
- Language note: Did the child use 'different, not wrong' spontaneously or only when prompted?
- Document: photograph approaches and annotate with the child's words about their method

EDUCATOR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- Were there children who found it genuinely difficult to accept that another approach was also valid? What might be driving that?
- How did you avoid implicitly signalling a preferred approach through your body language or attention?
- Where else in your program could you actively celebrate multiple valid approaches?

EYLF LINKS

This lesson directly supports EYLF Outcome 2 (Community) & Outcome 4 (Learning). Educators should record observations using anecdotal notes, photographs, or learning stories focused on children's language, body responses, and social interactions during the session.